

About this book

The core of this book is divided into two sections. The first, Plant Locations, recommends plants for different growing conditions. Part two, Plants for Special Effects, suggests plants suitable for different uses, including scent, and for various garden styles, such as Asian-style.

INTRODUCTION Gardening basics

PART ONE Plant Locations



Gardens in Sun



Gardens in Shade

PART TWO Plants for Special Effects



Plants for Garden Styles



Plants for Seasonal Interest



Plants for Color and Scent



Plants for Shape and Texture



Plants for Garden Problems

Plant focus pages Found within the Plant Locations section, these features give detailed advice on many popular groups of garden plants, such as grasses and sedges.

Plant focus: grasses and sedges

Elegant and versatile, the slender foliage and airy flowers of grasses and sedges contrast beautifully with broad-leaved plants.

ORNAMENTAL GRASSES AND SEDGES COMPREHEND A RANGE OF SHAPES AND SIZES, from tall and slender to short and squat, and form the key ingredients of many garden styles. Those with thin leaves and delicate flower heads, such as reed grass, blend perfectly into naturalistic schemes, while the spikes of blue fescue are ideal for container displays. Sedges, including those in the *Juncus* family, make elegant features in the boggy ground beneath water features. Although sedges and grasses look similar, they are adapted to different environments. With a few exceptions, grasses are deciduous and prefer sun and free-draining soils, while the majority of sedges are evergreen and happy in sun or shade and moist soils. Grasses also tend to have more dramatic flowers and seedheads adding to their decorative value. Both grasses and sedges help to lighten the heavey of winter landscapes: the leaves of deciduous species tend to remain intact throughout the season, providing useful structure in herbaceous borders.

POPULAR GRASS AND SEDGE SPECIES



Agrostis Sweet flag is an evergreen sedge with a dense clump of leaves and a long, thin flower spike. **Calamagrostis** Deciduous feather reed grass produces a low clump of leaves topped with tall, thin, golden-brown flower spikes. **Carex** This group of evergreen and deciduous sedges includes moisture-loving species, some of which are shade-tolerant. **Panicum** The most popular form of P. virgatum, a deciduous perennial grass with blue, oval, or purple-tinted foliage. **Pennisetum** Long, bottle-brush-like heads and narrow, blade-like leaves are features of this deciduous grass; some forms are tender. **Ships** Often used interchangeably with *Scilla*, many of these grasses feature feathery inflorescences from early summer to autumn.

USING GRASSES AND SEDGES

Grasses are used in prairie-style schemes for their summer foliage and feathery seed heads. Use sedges for year-round color and interest in the front of a bed.



Short compact grasses, such as *Scilla* and *Scilla*, are ideal for winter displays.



Tall slim-leaved grasses, such as *Scilla* and *Scilla*, provide contrasting textures and colors to herbaceous borders, while their feathery inflorescences add glimmers of the plants behind.

Broom-like forms of *Carex* and *Scilla* are ideal for winter displays in both modern and traditional garden designs.

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GARDENS IN SUN

Plants for sandy soil



SHRUB LARGE

Physocarpus opulifolius
NINEBARK A deciduous shrub with rounded lobed leaves. Compact, dome-shaped clusters of small white flowers appear in early summer, followed by reddish brown fruits. 'Diabolo' (above) sports deep purple foliage.
10ft (3m) → 15ft (5m)
⬆ 23-7 ⬆



SHRUB LARGE

Pittosporum tenuifolium
KOHUHU A columnar, later rounded, evergreen shrub or small tree with purple shoots and wavy-edged, oval, glossy midgreen leaves. In late spring, it bears tiny, honey-scented purple flowers. Best in West Coast gardens.
130ft (10m) → 15ft (5m)
⬆ 29-11



PERENNIAL SMALL

Potentilla 'Gibson's Scarlet'
CINQUEFOIL This clump-forming perennial has dark green leaves that resemble those of a strawberry plant. From early to late summer, it produces saucer-shaped, bright scarlet flowers on branching stems. It also grows in part shade.
18in (45cm) → 24in (60cm)
⬆ 25-8



SHRUB MEDIUM

Prunus tenella
DWARF RUSSIAN ALMOND This is a medium-sized, bushy, upright deciduous shrub with narrowly oval, glossy green leaves. From mid- to late spring, the stems are clothed in bright pink saucer-shaped flowers.
1-5ft (1.5m)
⬆ 22-6



PERENNIAL LARGE

Quercus coccinea
SCARLET OAK This deciduous tree forms a rounded head of glossy, dark green lobed leaves. In fall, the foliage turns bright red, producing a bold display that can last for several weeks. Small acorns form at the same time. Best in large gardens.
170ft (10m) → 50ft (15m)
⬆ 24-9 ⬆



PERENNIAL MEDIUM

Salvia x sylvestris
WOOD SAGE This is a compact perennial with small, dark green aromatic leaves. From early- to midsummer, 'May Night' (above) produces spikes of two-lipped, indigo-blue flowers over a long period. It is attractive to butterflies and bees.
132in (80cm) → 12in (30cm)
⬆ 24-9



SHRUB SMALL

Santolina chamaecyparissus
LAVERNA COTTON A rounded subshrub with soft, woolly, silvery white, finely divided foliage and short stems of yellow pom-pom flowers in summer. Trim after flowering. 'Lemon Queen' (above) has gray foliage and cream-colored blooms.
130in (75cm) → 3ft (1m)
⬆ 26-9



PERENNIAL MEDIUM

Scabiosa atropurpurea
PINCUSHION FLOWER This clump-forming perennial, grown as an annual, has lance-shaped gray-green leaves and masses of domed, lilac-purple summer flowers, adorned with feathery anthers that look like pins. Considered invasive in some areas.
13ft (1m) → 12in (30cm)
⬆ 29-11

Plant names Plants are listed by their Latin botanical names followed by a popular common name except in the herb and vegetable sections.

Key features The images focus on most important features of the plants and will not necessarily show its overall appearance and size.